

Maamarei Mordechai

הסבר לפי ממש פשוט

Parshas Eikev 5786

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The Torah's delicately chosen words teach paramount lessons.

וְהָיָה | עֲקֵב תִּשְׁמָעוֹן אֶת הַמִּשְׁפָּטִים הָאֵלֶּה וְשָׁמְרָתֶם וַעֲשִׂיתֶם אֹתָם וְשָׁמַר ה' אֱלֹהֵיךָ לָךְ
אֶת-הַבְּרִית וְאֶת-הַחֶסֶד אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לְאַבְתִּיךָ:

"And it shall be, you will supportively heed these ordinances and you shall guard them and perform them, and Hashem, your Lord, will guard for you, the covenant and the kindness that he promised to your forefathers." (Devarim 7:12).

This pasuk uses a few different adverbs in regards to adjuring Bnei Yisroel to keep the Torah. It also adds eikev – to support. Why does the Torah use different adverbs?

Had the Torah wished simply to introduce a condition, it could have said "if you listen.". Instead, it chose the unusual to add the word עֲקֵב. Literally, eikev means a heel. As a conjunction, however, it means in support of or to support. It also recalls the *cleaving* that Yaakov did to Eisav—when he clung to Eisva's heel and thus earned the name. The imagery is striking. Moshe is asking more than to hear and even more than to perform. A Yisroel must be a buttress for Torah and Mitzvos.

This pasuk has all the top words the Torah uses for Bnei Yisroel to keep the Torah. It has listen, guard, and perform. Yet *eikav* commences the pasuk, specifically. The Torah has a remarkable vocabulary that it employs. While a lazy English translation often renders several different Hebrew verbs simply as "obey," the Torah itself distinguishes carefully between them. Each verb highlights a different stage in man's relationship with Hashem and the mitzvos.

The first and perhaps most fundamental is שָׁמַע—to hear or listen. Its best-known appearance is, of course, שָׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל - Hear O' Yisroel. (Ibid 6:4). Likewise, the Torah promises, "And it will be if you shall surely listen..." (Ibid 11:13). More than hearing sounds, one obeys by first listening. Hearing implies accepting Hashem's word before acting upon it. Accordingly, shema frequently introduces passages of instruction, covenant renewal, or exhortation. While Bnei Yisroel is credited for saying "we will do and we will hear," normally, hearing proceeds doing.

A second verb appears repeatedly throughout the Torah, שָׁמַר—to guard or keep. "And you shall guard the mitzvos. (Ibid 8:1). Shamar conveys the image of protecting something precious. A watchman guards a city. Likewise, Bnei Yisroel is charged with preserving the Torah from neglect, compromise, or forgetfulness. It is no coincidence that shamar often appears alongside references to statutes and ordinances—the ceremonial and religious laws; emphasizing careful, continual observance.

Then comes the most practical verb of all: עָשָׂה—to perform. The Torah repeatedly commands, "and you shall perform them." (Ibid 7:11). Asah concerns actual performance. A commandment ultimately exists to be fulfilled. For this reason, it often follows shamar. One first guards the commandment, and then one performs it. Indeed,

the Torah frequently places these verbs side by side. The progression is intentional. One cannot faithfully perform what one has not first preserved.

Another recurring command is זָכַר – to recall. Zachar is rarely attached to ritual observance itself. Instead, it is consistently connected with Bnei Yisroel's history: "Remember that you were indentured servants in Egypt." (Ibid 5:15). "Remember what Amalek did to you." (Ibid 25:17). Even, "recall the Shabbos." (Shmos 20:8). The Torah understands that obedience begins with memory. Moreover, heritage is created by shared experiences and memories. A nation that forgets its past soon forgets its obligations and forgets itself. The commandments are rooted in history, and history becomes the motivation for faithfulness.

The Torah also repeatedly speaks of walking in Hashem's ways. "For you to walk in all His ways." (Devarim 8:6). Individual commandments are acts; walking describes a lifestyle. It speaks of one's direction in life rather than isolated deeds. This teaches how to perform the mitzvos. By walking in Hashem's ways, keeping the Torah becomes life itself and second nature.

Closely related is the command to love Hashem. (Ibid 6:5). Love is not presented as an emotion divorced from action. Rather, it becomes the motivation behind every commandment. Fear may restrain sin, but love inspires devotion. There is also a cycle. Hearing leads to guarding which leads to performing, which leads to recalling, which then inspires walking, and ultimately creates the bond of love.

Moshe also urges Bnei Yisroel לִדְבַק – to cling. (Ibid 10:20). This verb rarely introduces individual commandments. Instead, it appears in discussions of covenant loyalty and the rejection of idolatry. Once love is built, clinging describes a relationship more than legislation. The goal of the Torah is not merely compliance, but attachment to Hashem, Himself.

Our pasuk now takes on an even richer meaning. Moshe deliberately strings together several: listen, guard, and perform. Each word expresses a different dimension of serving Hashem, and different category of mitzvos. This is precisely why the Torah begins the parsha with eikev. The blessings of the covenant do not follow one particular type of religious devotion while neglecting another. They come "on the heels" of a complete life of Torah and mitzvos. Bnei Yisroel cannot be satisfied merely with learning Torah if it fails to observe it, nor can meticulous observance exist without first listening to and internalizing it. Likewise, outward performance without preserving the Torah's teachings for future generations falls short. In response, Hashem guards His side of the bris. Bnei Yisroel faithfully keeps the Torah, Hashem faithfully preserves them. Klal Yisroel remains steadfast in its obligations, Hashem remains steadfast in His promise of the covenant and loving-kindness that He swore to the forefathers.

Moshe's opening words therefore serve as more than an introduction to the parsha. They are a blueprint for Jewish life. Every facet of our relationship with Hashem matters. Listening with attentive hearts, guarding His Torah with unwavering commitment, and performing His mitzvos with faithful hands. None can replace the others; each is indispensable. Only when all of these work together does Israel fully uphold its covenant with Hashem – and then His blessings follow on their heels.